characterised by multiparty contests, it only means one thing: it has become the default party of the village there.

To put this in context, let us compare the BJP's rural depth with that of its competitors in UP: the SP, the BSP and the Congress. In the 2009–2019 period, while the BJP transformed into the dominant pole of politics in these rural areas, the support base of its main competitors either remained stagnant or drastically went down on the very same seats. The SP was way ahead of the BJP in 2009, winning more than 40 per cent votes in 17.3 per cent rural UP constituencies that year, but went down to 6.5 per cent in 2014. It recovered to 23.9 per cent in 2019, but the BJP still had three times that number. The BSP made major gains in rural UP in 2019, but even so had such deep-rooted vote-share support in only 26 per cent of the constituencies, while the Congress seriously declined to just a couple of such seats: Rahul Gandhi's Amethi and Sonia Gandhi's Raebareli (see Figure 2.2).

Figure 2.1: The BJP Significantly Expanded in the Rural Hindi Heartland, While the Congress Shrank (2009–2019)

